

“It’s possible to have a 25% growth out of India from now on”

Rail Europe Executive Chairman & CEO Björn Bender talks about the India market, the shift to digital, and the way ahead

PHOTOS BY HARDIK CHHABRA

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Björn Bender is the Executive Chairman & CEO of Rail Europe, one of the world’s largest distributors of European train tickets. Founded in 1932, the company was acquired by Hivest Capital, an independent French private equity firm, in early 2022. Bender, the face of the organisation, is probably the best ambassador for train travel in Europe. His family is based in Switzerland while the 43-year-old works in Paris, and every weekend, he makes the four-hour journey back home by train, a mode of transport he finds the most

convenient. In India, Rail Europe also sells tickets through its partners. In an interview with *Business Today’s Krishna Gopalan* during his recent visit to India, Bender speaks on the ever-increasing proportion of Indians travelling by train in Europe, the process of choosing newer destinations, and key travel trends. Edited excerpts:

Q: This is not your first visit to India. What are some of the changes that you see?

A: For one, I am not carrying a wallet, nor is there any cash in my pocket. I like travelling short distances by autorickshaw and about five years ago, all payment was made offline. Now, I see the [autorickshaw] drivers with smartphones, checking Instagram. Since I make all my bookings on Uber, I don’t pay 10 times the price, and the experience is very comfortable.

Q: Are most of your ticket bookings on Rail Europe done online today?

A: Yes, digital is a significant change for us. Before the pandemic, it was normal to see passengers with printouts. There is no concept of a [physical] ticket